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Haidt's theory of moral intuition (elephant and rider metaphor).

There is a powerful saying: **“We feel first, then we justify.”** This captures the main idea of Jonathan Haidt in *The Righteous Mind*. Haidt argues that moral decisions are not mainly the result of careful reasoning. Instead, they begin with intuition. We immediately feel that something is right or wrong, and only afterward do we search for logical reasons to defend that feeling.

To explain this, Jonathan Haidt uses the elephant and rider metaphor. The elephant represents intuition—emotional, automatic, and strong. The rider represents reason—slow, reflective, and analytical. The key point is that the elephant moves first. Our emotional reaction guides our moral judgment. The rider then creates arguments to justify the elephant's direction. This theory challenges the traditional belief that humans are primarily rational moral thinkers. It shows that emotion is not a weakness in morality; it is the foundation of it. From this insight, Jonathan Haidt developed Moral Foundations Theory (MFT). He proposes that humans are born with natural moral instincts—like built-in moral senses. However, culture shapes these instincts. Each society strengthens certain foundations while giving less importance to others. This explains why moral values differ across cultures, even though the basic moral structure is shared by all humans.

The Six Moral Foundations

1. Care vs. Harm

- The Care foundation is rooted in empathy and compassion. Humans naturally respond to suffering. When we see someone hurt or in danger, we feel concern and a desire to help. For example, If you see a person fall in the street and get injured, your immediate reaction is to help. You do not first analyze the situation deeply—you simply feel that helping is the right thing to do.

2. Fairness vs. Cheating

- Fairness is about justice, equality, and reciprocity. Humans evolved in cooperative groups where fairness ensured survival. People naturally dislike being cheated or treated unfairly. For example, imagine two employees working equally hard, but only one receives a bonus. Most people would immediately say that situation is unfair.

3. Loyalty vs. Betrayal

- Loyalty focuses on commitment to one's group, whether family, tribe, religion, or nation. Early humans survived because they stayed loyal to their tribe. For example, during a sports competition, fans strongly defend their team even if the team makes mistakes. If a player switches to a rival team, fans may feel betrayed.

4. Authority vs. Subversion

- Authority is about respect for hierarchy, tradition, and leadership. Stable authority structures historically helped maintain order and cooperation. For example, in some countries, students stand up when a teacher enters the room to show respect. In others, students remain seated and speak freely to teachers as equals.

5. Sanctity vs. Degradation

- Sanctity relates to purity, sacredness, and moral cleanliness. It originally developed as an instinct to avoid disease, but it later expanded into religious and cultural beliefs. For example, even if no one is physically harmed, burning a sacred religious book may create deep anger and moral outrage among believers. The reaction is not about physical harm but about violation of something sacred.

6. Liberty vs. Oppression

- Liberty centers on freedom and resistance to domination. Humans dislike being controlled or bullied. For example, if a government suddenly limits free speech or bans peaceful protests, many citizens may feel morally outraged and demand change.

How different cultures emphasize different foundations.

In many Western liberal democracies, **Care and Liberty** are strongly emphasized. Protecting individual rights, reducing suffering, and promoting freedom are central moral principles. Moral debates focus on equality, inclusion, and personal autonomy. In many collectivist societies, **Loyalty and Authority** receive stronger emphasis. Respect for elders, commitment to family, and maintaining social harmony are seen as essential moral duties. Publicly criticizing leaders may be viewed as harmful to unity. Religious societies often give strong importance to **Sanctity**. Moral rules about purity and sacred traditions influence daily life. Actions that violate sacred norms may be condemned even if they cause no physical harm. Economic systems also shape the meaning of **Fairness**. In capitalist societies, fairness may focus on merit and hard work. In welfare-oriented societies, fairness may emphasize equal support and social protection. As explained in *Patterns of Culture*, each culture selects certain traits and elevates them into moral ideals. Similarly, *Moral Man and Immoral Society* argues that social institutions and group interests strongly influence moral behavior. Morality is not formed in isolation. It develops within social systems that shape beliefs from childhood.